

Indicators in children's drawings as a tool for identifying sexual abuse

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ABSTRACT

Children often struggle to verbally express experiences of sexual abuse due to confusion, fear of consequences, or emotional bonds with the abuser; however, they may indirectly reveal aspects of these experiences through drawings. This study employed directed content analysis to examine emotional and behavioral indicators in the drawings of 28 children (13 girls and 15 boys) with confirmed histories of sexual abuse in Iran, the majority of whom (85%) were Afghan immigrants. Children were asked to draw a family picture and describe its features. Three researchers independently coded the drawings using a framework derived from prior studies, and discrepancies were resolved collaboratively.

Key visual indicators included floating objects, heavy pencil pressure, asymmetrical arms, one-dimensional forms, frog-like or monstrous figures, unstable feet, and horizontally positioned arms. These features appeared more frequently in drawings by children abused by their father, the mother's partner, or a male family acquaintance.

While these visual elements are not diagnostic markers of child sexual abuse, the findings suggest that drawing-based cues may offer clinicians complementary insights into children's emotional states—such as fear, anxiety, insecurity, aggression, or low self-image—particularly when verbal disclosure is difficult. Given the absence of a control group and the cultural specificity of the sample, the results should be interpreted with caution and may not be generalizable to other populations.

1. Introduction

More than half of children worldwide are exposed to violence in various forms each year (Lev-Wiesel et al., 2018). A large-scale epidemiological survey indicates that 52% of adults have experienced some form of abuse at least once in their lifetime (Lev-Wiesel et al., 2019). These individuals have reported different types of abuse, both within and outside their families, perpetrated by adults or peers (Oriol et al., 2017). Similarly, studies show that one in five people has suffered some form of sexual violence during childhood (Ballús et al., 2023; Thang et al., 2017). Experiencing various types of maltreatment—including sexual abuse—during childhood is associated with long-term negative physical and psychological consequences that persist into adulthood (Warmingham et al., 2019). Sexual abuse plays a significant role in the development of personality disorders, sexual dysfunction, substance abuse, and psychosis (Read et al., 2018). It can damage trust and intimacy (Somer & Szwarcberg, 2001), lead to increased psychological distress, functional impairments, and poorer

psychological adaptation among victims. Furthermore, it raises the risk of developing issues such as anxiety, depression (Engstrom et al., 2021), PTSD, and physical and verbal aggression in children (Ionio & Mascheroni, 2021).

In addition, sexual abuse plays a key role in the emergence of dissociation among affected children (Tsur & Katz, 2022). Dissociation is a mental process characterized by a disconnection or separation from thoughts, feelings, memories, and the surrounding environment, which can impact an individual's sense of identity and perception of time (Mucci & Scalabrini, 2021). Children who experience sexual abuse are hospitalized more frequently and for longer periods (Read et al., 2018), and they face a higher risk of self-harm or suicide (Ballús et al., 2023).

There is a significant gap between the occurrence of child abuse and its disclosure (Gewehr et al., 2021). Statistics indicate that fewer than 10% of children disclose experiences of sexual abuse, and approximately 70% are reluctant to report such incidents to professionals (Lev-Wiesel et al., 2019). As victims, children often have difficulty verbally expressing the abuse they have endured. In other words, they encounter

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challenges in communicating about the issue (Ionio & Mascheroni, 2021). Moreover, they may not fully comprehend what is happening to them (Goldner et al., 2021). Furthermore, these children fear the negative consequences that disclosing the abuse may have on themselves and potentially on the abuser, as child abuse frequently occurs within families or through close social relationships. They may be threatened with punishment by the abuser and their supporters. Additionally, they worry that others will not believe them or that they will encounter negative reactions from non-offending parents and relatives (McInnes, 2019). Consequently, these children may be blamed for such allegations and may face further harm (McInnes, 2019). In addition to social, emotional, and cultural barriers, nondisclosure of child sexual abuse may also be associated with neurobiological consequences of trauma. Research indicates that childhood sexual abuse can affect brain development and functioning, particularly in areas involved in autobiographical memory, emotion regulation, and verbal processing (Teicher & Samson, 2016; Tomoda et al., 2025). Such alterations may reduce a child's ability to coherently access, organize, or verbalize traumatic experiences, potentially contributing to delayed or limited disclosure. While this does not imply a deterministic inability to report abuse, it highlights the need for nonverbal assessment tools (e.g., drawing) that may be especially helpful for children whose verbal expression could be compromised by trauma-related neurobiological processes.

Many children do not perceive such experiences as sufficiently serious, often failing to recognize them as abusive incidents. In some cases, they view such experiences as a normal part of daily life, which contributes to their decision not to report them (Lahtinen et al., 2022). Additionally, feelings of shame and the severity of the abuse further exacerbate this silence (McInnes, 2019). Research indicates that the severity of sexual abuse correlates with an increased reluctance to disclose it (Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022). Studies conducted in Asian countries generally report lower prevalence rates of child sexual abuse compared to non-Asian countries. This discrepancy may be attributed to genuinely lower rates of abuse in these countries (Piolanti et al., 2025; Selengia et al., 2020; Stoltenborgh et al., 2011), less willingness to disclose due to cultural barriers (Nguyen et al., 2010), or a combination of both. In many Asian countries, sexual taboos, social shame, and concerns about family reputation lead to lower willingness among children and families to report abuse or seek support (Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022). Furthermore, variations in data collection methods and the complexities of measuring the prevalence of child sexual abuse may also impact the differences in reported rates (Piolanti et al., 2025; Stoltenborgh et al., 2011).

Despite these challenges, children who experience abuse can indirectly disclose their experiences through their behavior or drawings. Drawing serves as a natural and spontaneous form of communication for children, allowing them to express their distressing experiences through non-verbal methods (Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022). Generally, children are capable of articulating their hidden or repressed thoughts and feelings through drawing (Limor et al., 2019), which provides access to their unconscious and mental experiences (Goldner & Frid, 2022). Many believe that children's drawings either reflect their self-image, represent their aspirations, or depict aspects they wish to avoid (Deguara & Nutbrown, 2018). According to these researchers, colors, shapes, and patterns can unconsciously illustrate ideas, troubling emotions, and concerns, thereby adding layers of meaning to verbal content (Goldner & Scharf, 2017).

Using drawing as a powerful complement to other data collection methods can help therapists gain a better understanding of individuals' perceptions of pathology and well-being (Boden et al., 2019). While children's drawings alone may not be sufficient for identifying sexual abuse, they can enhance professionals' sensitivity, especially when combined with verbal expressions, which add greater meaning and clarity (Deguara & Nutbrown, 2018).

One of the key advantages of drawing as a tool is that it allows

children to express their experiences without the need for verbal communication, reducing the risk of exposing them to stressful situations or stimuli. This non-verbal method can be especially helpful for frightened children who may be reluctant to discuss their experiences (Pace et al., 2022). Furthermore, research indicates that drawings can encourage verbal expression of traumatic experiences and facilitate detailed descriptions, helping the individual who created the drawing to view their negative experiences more objectively (Goldner et al., 2021; Lev-Wiesel & Liraz, 2007). Additionally, drawing aids children who have experienced sexual abuse in articulating more details and discussing their experiences in a more coherent manner (Katz et al., 2018).

In this context, various studies have suggested that the drawings of sexually abused children may exhibit certain graphic characteristics that can differ from those of individuals who have not experienced abuse (Kissos et al., 2020). Familiarity with such characteristics may help educators and other professionals, such as social workers, become more attentive to possible signs of emotional distress or adverse experiences, particularly when the child's behavior and narratives are considered alongside other contextual information. Accordingly, this study aims to use drawing as a tool to explore descriptive indicators in children's drawings that may warrant further attention in cases of suspected sexual abuse. Identifying such indicators may increase professionals' sensitivity to children's drawings and provide a basis for further investigation. Therefore, the main research question is: What elements or indicators are present in the drawings of children who have experienced sexual abuse?

2. Method

2.1. Study design

This study employed content analysis to examine children's drawings. Content analysis is a qualitative research method commonly used in psychology and child development studies to interpret the symbolic and emotional meanings embedded in visual or textual data (Vaismoradi et al., 2013). The primary aim of this study was to identify behavioral and emotional indicators associated with the experience of sexual abuse in children's drawings. Specifically, the content analysis was conventional and descriptive, focusing on identifying and categorizing features and signs present in the drawings based on theoretical frameworks and empirical literature.

2.2. Participants and setting

The target group for this research consisted of children admitted to Nedaye Mandegar Institute, a non-governmental organization (NGO) located in the Harandi neighborhood of Tehran, Iran. This institute focuses on empowering women who are heads of households through vocational training and economic support. The center also operates a childcare and preschool program for their children. Some children also attend the center even though their mothers are not employed, but they are admitted due to severe financial hardship. All participating children were six or seven years old, an important developmental stage in which cognitive, emotional, and motor skills significantly affect how and what children draw (Cox, 2013). For participation in this study, children had to be identified as victims of sexual abuse by the center's psychologists and social workers. Identification was based on standardized assessment procedures, including clinical interviews, psychological evaluations, and social assessments involving home visits and evaluation of family conditions. Ethical protocols were strictly followed, and informed consent was obtained from the children's mothers prior to participation.

A total of 30 children were eligible, and 28 children (13 girls and 15 boys) volunteered and completed the drawing activity. Children were divided into six small groups of four to five participants to facilitate a comfortable and manageable drawing environment. In addition to age and sex, basic demographic information indicated that approximately

85% of the participating children were Afghan immigrants. This is a significant contextual detail, as most participants came from refugee families who had experienced social marginalization and displacement due to conflict and violence in Afghanistan. Such background conditions may influence both the emotional content and symbolic representations in the children's drawings and were therefore taken into account during the interpretive phase.

2.2.1. Data collection procedures

The Family Drawing Test, a widely used psychological tool for assessing family relationships and individual emotions, was employed for data collection. This test is frequently used in evaluating children, particularly in cases involving anxiety, fear, and psychological distress (Pace et al., 2022; Sanglard et al., 2022). It offers an opportunity to observe and analyze visual characteristics in children's drawings, which can help uncover hidden signs of emotional and psychological experiences. Prior to analysis, an initial pool of drawing indicators was compiled based on established psychological literature and recent empirical studies on children's graphic expression (e.g., Allen & Tussey, 2012; Blain et al., 1981; Cherney & Seiwert, 2020; Cohen-Liebman, 1995; Dağhoğlu et al., 2010; Goldner et al., 2021; Guo et al., 2023; Jacobs-Kayam et al., 2013; Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022; Lev-Wiesel et al., 2024; Limor et al., 2019; Ram-Vlasov et al., 2019; Sidun & Rosenthal, 1987). This preliminary list included a broad range of visual features, such as omission of self, abnormal body proportions, excessive pencil pressure, monstrous or distorted figures, and disproportionate emphasis on sexual body parts, which have been described as possible indicators of emotional distress or trauma. These features served as the initial pool from which the coding framework for the present study was refined and were subsequently applied in the coding process by three independent researchers.

2.2.2. Drawing task and interview protocol

Children were instructed: "Please draw a family. You can include anyone you think makes a family. Draw them the way you see them in your mind." This instruction was intentionally kept open-ended to avoid imposing the idea that they must depict their own family specifically, and to allow free expression of the concept of "family" from the child's perspective.

It was initially planned to collect three drawings from each child, focusing on the theme of family, at two-week intervals. However, due to factors such as physical illness, reluctance to continue participation, or changes in residence, some children completed only one or two drawings. The number of drawings completed varied: three children completed one drawing, seventeen children completed two drawings, and eight children completed three drawings each. This variation reflects differences in engagement and availability. The research team closely monitored the drawing process. Each child received a sheet of paper, a pencil, a box of colored pencils, and an eraser. To minimize peer influence, the children were seated at a distance from one another. After completing their drawings, the children were gently praised with encouraging comments such as, "That's great!" or "Well done!" Subsequently, the research team asked the following interview questions: "Now tell me about these people. Who are they?" "Where are they?" "What are they doing?" and "Start with the one you drew first." Additional questions about the role, gender, and estimated age of each person depicted in the drawing were also posed. These questions were asked calmly, with pauses to ensure the children did not feel pressured.

2.2.3. Coding and analysis process

The final coding framework was developed by refining and organizing the initial pool of indicators into a structured set of visual features. Indicators related to human figures are presented in Table 1, while additional non-human and environmental features are shown in Fig. 2. These indicators reflect visual patterns that have been described in previous research as possible markers of emotional distress or disrupted

Table 1
Signs in the drawn figures.

No.	Sign	Percentage (%)	No.	Sign	Percentage (%)
1	Asymmetry of the arms	64	36	Omission of the brother's mouth	18
2	Unstable legs	64	37	Omission of the brother's legs	18
3	Shading on parts of the body	61	38	Distance from family members	18
4	Deformed body	57	39	Omission of one's own legs	14
5	Omission of the arms	57	40	Omission of the father's legs	14
6	Monstrous-shaped figures	54	41	Drawing of a nose	14
7	Horizontal arms	46	42	Drawing of the father's ears	14
8	Drawing of hair	46	43	Large hands	11
9	Omission of one's own figure	43	44	Long legs	11
10	Omission of the mother's mouth	43	45	Omission of the eyes	11
11	Angled human figures	39	46	Long arms	11
12	Hollowed eyes	39	47	Drawing of teeth	11
13	Defacing of human figures	39	48	Short legs	11
14	Omission of the upper body	39	49	Closed eyes	11
15	Omission of the brother	39	50	Father's wide lips	11
16	Omission of the mother's legs	36	51	Drawing of the brother's ears	11
17	Special or unusual eyes	36	52	Drawing of the sister's ears	11
18	Large eyes with small pupils	32	53	Confining someone to the house	11
19	Omission of the mother	29	54	Omission of the father's mouth	7
20	Asymmetry of the eyes	29	55	Asymmetry of the hands	7
21	Omission of the body's marginal line	29	56	Depiction younger than actual age	7
22	Asymmetry of the legs	25	57	Drawing of the mother's ears	7
23	Short arms	25	58	Drawing figures from the back view	7
24	Wide arms	25	59	Omission of the soles	7
25	Linear and inflexible fingers	25	60	Omission of the sister's hands	7
26	Fan-shaped fingers	21	61	Drawing of one's own ears	7
27	Omission of the father	21	62	Omission of one's own hands	4
28	Omission of one's own mouth	21	63	Omission of the mother's hands	4
29	Slim and weak arms	21	64	Open arms	4
30	Drawing of the self in a different color	21	65	Drawing of the navel	4
31	Arms attached to the head	21	66	Large legs	4
32	Omission of the sister's mouth	18	67	Arms attached to the waist	4
33	Dot-shaped eyes	18	68	Sister's wide lips	4
34	Omission of the sister's legs	18	69	Brother's wide lips	4
35	Omission of the sister	18	70	Very small human figures	4

This table presents a comprehensive list of 70 coded visual indicators, including both frequent and less frequent signs identified in the drawings.

functioning in children (Allen & Tussey, 2012; Blain et al., 1981; Cherney & Seiwert, 2020; Cohen-Liebman, 1995; Dağlıoğlu et al., 2010; Goldner et al., 2021; Guo et al., 2023; Jacobs-Kayam et al., 2013; Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022; Lev-Wiesel et al., 2021; Limor et al., 2019; Ram-Vlasov et al., 2019; Sidun & Rosenthal, 1987). In the present study, this refined framework was systematically applied to code the drawings of children who had been identified by the center's psychologists and social workers as having experienced sexual abuse.

Each drawing was analyzed by three independent researchers using a standardized coding sheet. The presence or absence of each indicator was recorded using a binary coding system (1 = present, 0 = absent). This systematic approach enhanced transparency and replicability of the analysis (Erlingsson & Brysiewicz, 2017; Vaismoradi et al., 2013).

During the initial coding phase, coders independently identified the presence or absence of specific visual indicators in the drawings using the standardized coding manual. In rare cases where ambiguity arose—such as with elements potentially resembling genitalia—the drawings were re-examined by the research team, and decisions were made based on the consensus of at least two out of three researchers. This interpretive consensus ensured consistency and enhanced the reliability of visual indicator classification.

To minimize bias in the initial analysis, a separate team of trained coders—who had no access to trauma histories or family background—was recruited. All coders underwent preparatory training through four intensive workshops conducted by a clinical psychologist and a child development expert. The training included the theoretical foundations of the Family Drawing Test, familiarization with coding indicators, and practice scoring using sample drawings to ensure consistency and reliability. Coders were provided only with basic demographic information (age and sex) and applied the coding manual independently of any background information. To assess inter-rater reliability, Cohen's Kappa coefficient was calculated for each indicator. In this study, κ values ranged from 0.72 to 0.84, indicating strong inter-rater reliability.

2.2.4. Trustworthiness and interpretation procedures

To further enhance trustworthiness and minimize subjectivity, a detailed coding manual was developed and discussed among the research team prior to analysis. However, to ensure a comprehensive and contextualized interpretation of the findings, the core research team later integrated three sources of data during the interpretive phase:

(1) the coded features of the drawings (2) the children's verbal expressions during the drawing process, and (3) the background information obtained from social workers, caregivers, or institutional files.

Each case was thus interpreted holistically, with special attention to how visual indicators aligned with the child's narrative and psychosocial context. In instances of ambiguity, the team re-examined the drawings in light of all available information and reached interpretive consensus. This two-phase process—objective initial coding followed by contextualized interpretation—was intended to enhance both the reliability and ecological validity of the study's findings.

2.2.5. Ethical considerations

Prior to conducting the drawing sessions, the purpose of the study and the manner of data dissemination were explained to the legal guardians or next of kin. Informed consent forms were obtained, ensuring the strict confidentiality and anonymity of the participants' information. Ethical considerations, including the well-being of the participants, were upheld throughout the study. As part of the ethical and educational component of the research, the team conducted four training sessions with all six groups of participating children. These sessions focused on child abuse prevention, body boundaries, and strategies for responding to potentially harmful or inappropriate situations. This initiative aimed to empower children and ensure that the research process also served a protective and supportive function.

3. Findings

Before presenting the findings, it is important to clarify how the visual indicators were interpreted and quantified. Interpretations were based on a triangulated analysis that incorporated the drawings, the children's verbal explanations, and contextual information from caregivers. Thus, the visual signs discussed below should be understood within each child's broader social and familial context rather than as standalone diagnostic markers. In this study, the unit of analysis was the child. Visual indicators were aggregated across all drawings produced by each child, resulting in a single profile per participant. Consequently, a child who created multiple drawings was not given additional weight in the analysis, and all percentages reported in the results section reflect the proportion of children who exhibited each indicator.

This section presents the key visual and symbolic indicators identified in the children's drawings through content analysis, with a focus on the most frequently observed patterns and illustrative examples. These findings may provide insight into the emotional and psychological experiences of children who had experienced sexual abuse (Fig. 1).

Among the prominent indicators observed in the children's drawings were floating figures and objects.

Asymmetry of the arms (18 children, 64%), unstable legs (18 children, 64%), shading on parts of the body (17 children, 61%), deformed body (16 children, 57%), omission of the arms (16 children, 57%), monstrous-shaped figures (15 children, 54%), horizontal arms (13 children, 46%), drawing of hair (13 children, 46%), omission of one's own figure (12 children, 43%), and omission of the mother's mouth (12 children, 43%) were among the most frequently observed elements in the drawn human figures.

Other frequently observed signs in the children's drawings included the repetition of wedges (11 children, 39%), deformed houses and doors (11 children, 39%), houses without doors or windows (11 children, 39%), and repeated hearts and circular shapes (10 children, 36%).

To illustrate these broader patterns, several individual drawings are presented below. For example, the drawing produced by Participant Code 5-1 includes floating objects and figures, a house without doors or windows, intense pencil pressure in the depiction of the house, and wedge-shaped forms (Fig. 3).

In the drawing produced by Participant Code 6-2, several notable features were observed, including asymmetrical legs, the omission of both the child and the father, and the depiction of a figure described by the child as an "addicted thief." This figure appears as the rightmost human figure in the drawing, while the mother is depicted on the far left. According to the caregiver interview, the mother explained that the father was a substance user who occasionally stole household items to sell. In light of this contextual information, the research team inferred that the figure labeled by the child as an "addicted thief" likely represented the father. Additional indicators in this drawing included the absence of the mother's hands and the missing legs of the figure referred to as the "addicted thief." While describing the picture, the child added, "My sister has a very bad secret in her hands" (Fig. 4).

Some participants made direct references to sexual abuse in their drawings. For instance, Participant Code 20 initially depicted themselves and one of their brothers under a blanket but later erased that section. However, they still included other family members on the bed in their drawing (Fig. 5).

Participant Code 20 stated, "Zubair—my brother—puts his hand in my pants at night and says, 'Don't tell anyone or I will tell Dad to beat you.' He does this when I am asleep." During an interview with the child's mother, it was found that the child sleeps next to their oldest brother, who is 18 years old. However, when explaining the drawing, the child mentioned a younger brother. It appears that threats from or fear of the older brother may have prevented the child from disclosing the abuser's identity. Avoidance or misattribution of the abuser's identity can function as a coping strategy when fear or threat is involved. In this context, Participant Code 17 explained his drawing by stating: "My

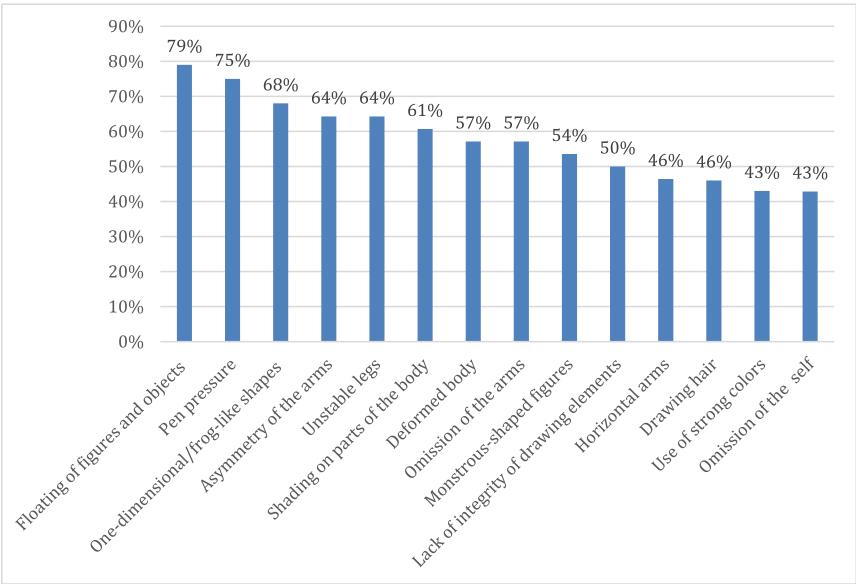


Fig. 1. The most common visual features in the drawings:
This figure summarizes the most frequently observed visual features in the drawings of the participating children.

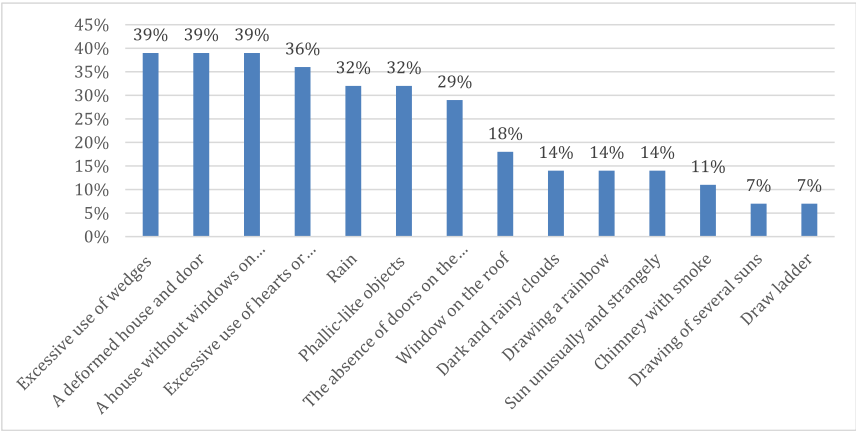


Fig. 2. Non-human symbols drawn by children with a history of sexual abuse.

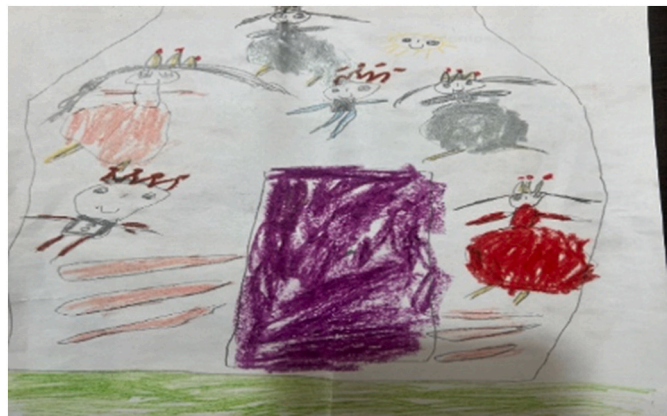


Fig. 3. Drawing created by Participant Code 5-1.



Fig. 4. Drawing created by Participant Code 6-2.

father's thing is always out here (he pointed to his father's penis). Everyone sees it. My dad keeps telling me to touch him.”
The explicit depiction of genitalia in the drawings of Participant

Codes 17 and 28 was recorded as a notable visual feature and is interpreted further in the discussion section (Figs. 6, 7).

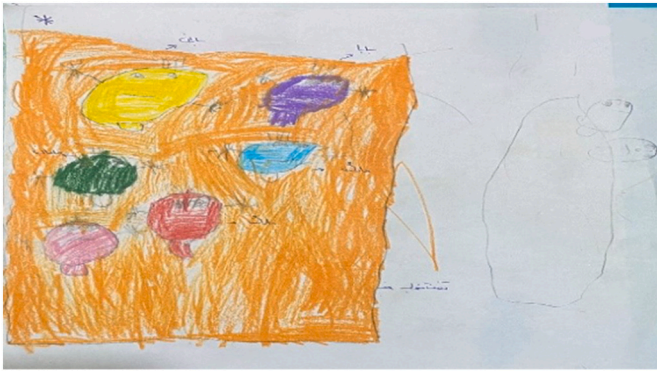


Fig. 5. Drawing created by Participant Code 20.



Fig. 6. Drawing created by Participant Code 17.



Fig. 7. Drawing created by Participant Code 28.

In the drawing produced by Participant Code 28, several notable visual features were observed, including a house positioned in the upper part of the page without a clear ground line and limited or obscured facial detail. The facial area of one of the human figures appears visually defaced, while the overall spatial arrangement gives the house a detached or floating quality in relation to the rest of the scene.

Participant Codes 2 and 23—both of whom were abused by their mothers' partners—and Participant Code 22, who was abused by his uncle, depicted the father figure as lacking arms or hands in their

drawings. In Participant Code 22's drawing, the father is positioned on the left side of the image, whereas in Participant Code 2's drawing, the human figure positioned at the top left of the page was identified by the child as the father. The omission of the father's arms or hands may reflect the children's perceptions of their fathers' emotional unavailability or limited ability to protect them, given the difficult circumstances of their lives. Based on established interpretive guidelines in child-drawing analysis, such as those described by [Cherney and Seiwert \(2020\)](#), the absence of arms or hands can—but does not necessarily—symbolize perceived helplessness, lack of agency, or fear associated with relational conflict or violence.

Importantly, these interpretations were not derived from the visual characteristics alone. They were supported by the children's verbal explanations during the interviews and the contextual information provided by their caregivers. Therefore, the meaning attributed to these omissions should be understood as emerging from the combined analysis of the drawings and the accompanying narratives, rather than from the drawings in isolation ([Figs. 8, 9](#)).

In some cases, participants did not depict the mother's hands or arms, which may suggest a perceived limitation in the mother's ability to influence or change the family situation; however, this interpretation remains tentative and depends on the broader contextual information.

In the drawing produced by Participant Code 16, for example, the mother is positioned as the third figure from the left, slightly above the house, and is drawn without hands. Participant Code 16 reported observing his mother's efforts to protect him from his abusive father. However, according to the caregiver interview, these efforts were constrained by the mother's addiction, severe poverty, and involvement in sex work ([Figs. 10, 11](#)).

Another indicator that appeared in some drawings was the depiction of confinement, in which the child or a family member was shown enclosed within the home. For example, in the drawing produced by Participant Code 16-2, the child depicted his father locked inside the house. The child's mother confirmed that both she and the paternal grandparents had been physically violent toward the child. Although she did not explicitly state that the father assaulted the child, she did not contradict this possibility, while the child repeatedly stated to social workers, "My father puts his hand inside my underwear." Some children (Code 14-1, Code 19) also portrayed themselves as confined within the home. This portrayal may reflect an attempt to visually distance themselves from family members perceived as threatening; however, this interpretation remains tentative and should be understood only in relation to the child's reported experiences and contextual information ([Figs. 12, 13](#)).

Participant Code 14-2 depicted his father in the drawing and explained in the interview: "My father has a secret; his secret is between his legs," referring to the father's genital area. In the upper left corner of the page, a small and unclear figure was drawn; when asked, the child



Fig. 8. Drawing created by Participant Code 2.



Fig. 9. Drawing created by Participant Code 22.



Fig. 12. Drawing created by Participant Code 14-1.

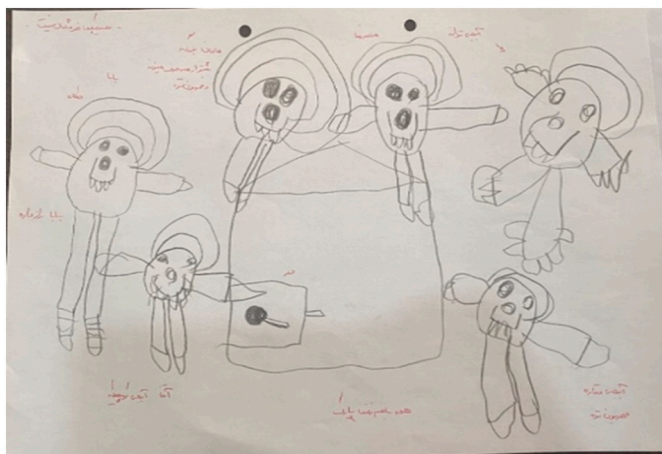


Fig. 10. Drawing created by Participant Code 16-1.



Fig. 13. Drawing created by Participant Code 19.

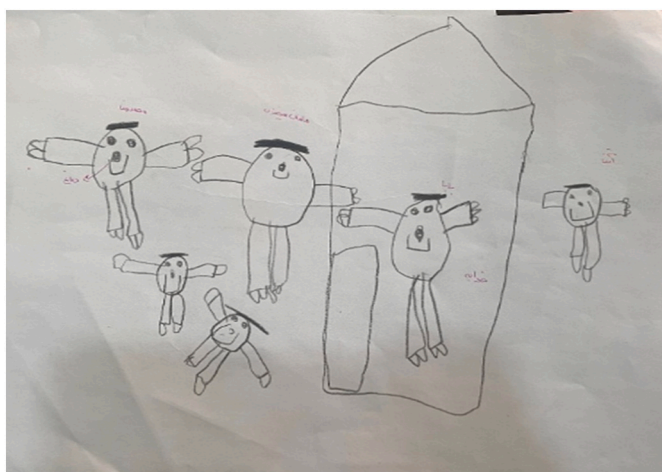


Fig. 11. Drawing created by Participant Code 16-2.

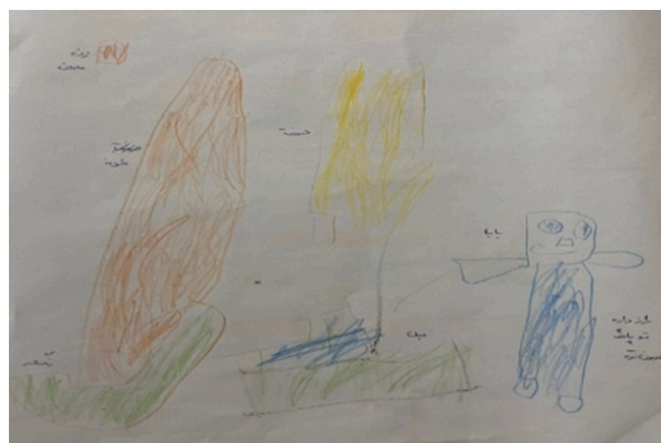


Fig. 14. Drawing created by Participant Code 14-2.

identified this figure as his mother. The notably small scale of the mother, compared with the other figures, might imply a perceived emotional distance or limited influence, although such interpretations remain tentative. In both drawings, the child depicted his own head in the first drawing and his father's head in the second drawing at an angle. This angled depiction was observed in drawings by 11 children (39%), making it one of the recurring visual patterns identified across participants (Fig. 14).

Participant Code 4 depicted his family members inside a house that resembled a prison, while placing himself at a distance from them. Although the family had taken steps to limit the abusive relative's access to the child, the drawing suggests that the child still did not perceive himself as fully separate or free from the situation. This visual

arrangement could indicate unresolved feelings of emotional confinement; however, it should not be interpreted as a direct representation of the child's real-life circumstances without additional corroborating information (Fig. 15).

Another participant (Code 1) did not depict a recognizable house structure, despite including windows and doors. During the interview, he explained: "Strangers can look at us from the window, and a man wanted to pull the blanket from the room and see my private part. Our neighbor's son also wants to touch my private part." In his account, he referred to multiple individuals attempting to access or touch his genital area. In the drawing created by Participant Code 1, no walls enclosing the space were depicted, despite the presence of doors and windows. If interpreted in this way, it could suggest that the child does not perceive a protective boundary separating him from external dangers. Such an omission might reflect a perceived sense of vulnerability and exposure to threat (Fig. 16).

Participant Code 17, who had been abused by his father, depicted both his own eyes and his father's eyes without pupils—a pattern observed in approximately 5 out of 28 children (18%) in the sample. This percentage is descriptive only and should not be interpreted as statistically or diagnostically significant. Neither the child's face nor the adult's face includes identifiable facial features; both are fully filled with color. The father's arms and legs were drawn in an asymmetrical and exaggerated manner. The drawing also included rainy weather and several objects whose shapes resemble phallic forms.

Across this child's drawings (Code 23), several phallic-like shapes appear, one of which the child labeled as a house. This particular shape has a rounded, pink-colored top that visually resembles a phallic form. The remainder of the drawing includes natural elements such as clouds and flowers, as well as bird-like figures (Fig. 18, 19).

Participant Code 27 appears to depict himself in a diminished form, using pale lines and portraying himself without hands or a mouth, as well as presenting himself as younger than his actual age. He shaded his father's hand and defaced the father's face. According to reports from social workers, the child is being abused by his father; however, both the mother and the child disclosed abuse only by another relative. Another notable feature in these children's drawings was the depiction of multiple suns or suns drawn in unusual or distorted forms.

In Child 3's drawing, the mother is depicted faintly in the upper-left area of the page. The child also appears to have represented himself faintly in the upper-right portion of the page, with one arm extended toward the maternal figure. When considered alongside the child's narrative, this configuration may suggest a perception of the mother as emotionally distant, less accessible, or insufficiently protective. During the interview, the child stated: "When my mother does not see, my friend takes me to the bathroom and pulls down my pants.... When I change my clothes in the kitchen, he watches me through the keyhole."



Fig. 15. Drawing created by Participant Code 4.



Fig. 16. Drawing created by Participant Code 1.

The figures located in the lower part of the page were identified by the child as the father and brothers. Their vertical separation from the upper figures may be tentatively interpreted as reflecting psychological distance within the child's internal representation of family relationships. In addition, the human figures are markedly simplified: facial features are minimal, the legs are rendered in a one-dimensional manner, and in all cases only one arm is depicted.

In Child 7's drawing, the mother is absent, while the father and two brothers are depicted. The girl's facial expression on the right side of the image appears worried or apprehensive, and the father is drawn disproportionately large. This child was sexually abused by her father. In describing the drawing, she stated: "Dad has a secret in his pants." The father's hand extends above the child's head, which may be interpreted as suggesting dominance or control.

In Participant Code 1's drawing, the contour lines of the father's face are omitted. The child depicted himself above the father's head and with a relatively large head. This spatial positioning may suggest the father's psychological salience in the child's internal experience or a degree of preoccupation with him. The hair is drawn in a disorganized manner with sharp lines. Other notable features of the drawing include distorted body forms and the presence of rain. Taken together, these elements may convey an overall impression of emotional turmoil or psychological pressure.

In Participant 3's drawing, the father is depicted on the right, the mother in the center, and the sister on the left, while the participant herself is absent from the image. The mother's head is drawn larger than those of the other figures, which may suggest greater psychological salience in the child's internal representation. At the same time, the mother's figure is depicted incompletely, and parts of her body—including the hands, legs, and portions of the torso—appear to have been omitted or erased. It is also noteworthy that, according to the child's account, she had also been subjected to physical violence by her mother; a point that may be relevant to the interpretation of the mother's representation in the drawing. Other notable features of this drawing include pronounced hair, sharp and linear fingers, and the omission of facial details in the figures. In a cautious reading, these elements may be consistent with the experience of a tense or emotionally unstable environment.

Participant Code 20 had been sexually abused by her brother. According to the mother's account, although the father had repeatedly stated that he did not love his children and did not live with them, the child continually asked about him and wished that they could live with him. In this drawing, the child depicted herself between the parental representations; the second figure from the left represents the participant herself. The family consisted of six sons and three daughters; however, the participant drew only her three sisters and did not include her five brothers in the representation. It also appears that some of these figures may have been drawn initially and then erased. In a cautious

reading, this omission may reflect a form of psychological distancing from figures associated with stress or distress. In addition, the house is depicted as large and dark, whereas the human figures are small and positioned at the bottom of the page. This spatial organization may suggest that the home environment occupied a dominant, salient, or highly determining place in the child's experience; an impression that is not particularly consistent with the image of a warm, egalitarian, and playful family environment.

In Participant 21's drawing, the father figure is depicted as markedly larger and more visually intimidating than the other family members. In light of the mother's account that, while the family was living in Afghanistan, the Taliban carried out a nighttime attack, tied the father's hands and feet, and took the child hostage, this magnified representation may be consistent with the father's psychological salience in the child's internal experience. At the same time, the omission of the father's arms may, in a cautious reading, be understood as suggesting perceived helplessness, limitation, or reduced agency in the child's mind. The mother is drawn at the center of the picture with open, horizontally extended arms; this feature may be consistent with the child's experience of the mother as emotionally available or supportive during the crisis, particularly in light of her supportive role during the hostage-taking and the sexual assault the child endured. The child is also depicted as turned away from the parents, which may reflect avoidance, relational insecurity, or difficulty trusting family relationships. In addition, the facial expressions of the drawn figures, together with the sharp, upward-pointing hair, may convey an overall atmosphere of tension, disorganization, or emotional arousal.

In Child 7's drawing, the presence of visible teeth, exaggerated hair, the use of intense colors, heavy pressure, distorted figures, and hollow eyes may collectively be consistent with the experience of a highly aroused and unsettled family environment. In a cautious reading, the very large and dominant sun may also suggest the salience of a powerful emotional or external presence within the child's psychological landscape. This interpretation becomes more meaningful when considered alongside the child's narrative, in which she repeatedly referred to individuals who had attempted to touch or look at her private parts and stated that she had disclosed these incidents to her mother. In other drawings by this participant, the mother was depicted as the most distant figure from the child. In the present drawing as well, although the child appears to represent herself—second from the right—next to her mother—the first figure on the right—the mother's gaze does not seem to be directed toward her. Taken together, this pattern may cautiously be interpreted as reflecting the child's perception of emotional distance, not being fully seen, or an insufficiently protective maternal presence (Fig. 27).

In Participant Code 10-2's drawing, the family figures are depicted with relatively small heads and markedly elongated, exaggerated bodies. The faces lack detail and appear obscured, while the hands and feet are either omitted or rendered only vaguely in most figures. In addition, the bodily contours appear loose and unstable in some areas. Taken together, these features may be consistent with a degree of instability in the organization of the human figures and reduced cohesion in bodily representation (Fig. 28).

In Participant Code 6-1's drawing, the father is depicted within a kind of pink halo. Given that the father was omitted in the child's other drawings, this representation may suggest that the father occupied a psychologically salient or tension-laden position in the child's internal experience. In a cautious reading, this colored halo may reflect a form of enclosure, emphasis, or psychological distancing in relation to the father. In explaining the other drawings, the child had stated that the father was not depicted because "he is at work." In the present drawing, the child portrayed herself between the mother and the father, and the arrangement of the figures may indicate a relational orientation toward the mother. This participant also rendered the sky and the ground with considerable color pressure and placed the sun behind the clouds. The distorted body forms, the indistinct faces, and the looseness of bodily

boundaries in some figures are additional notable features of this image that, taken together, may be consistent with an atmosphere of tension or emotional disturbance (Fig. 29).

Participant Code 10-1 depicted his mother as taller than the other family members. The child stated, "I tell my secret to my mom. My mom is going to kill him with a knife," and reported being sexually abused by his father. The disproportionate height of the mother may suggest the child's need to perceive her as a more powerful or protective figure; however, such interpretations remain tentative, as variations in size can also reflect developmental drawing tendencies rather than specific psychological meanings (Fig. 30).

Participant Code 12-1 depicted his mother with tearful eyes positioned between himself and his father. He drew himself and his mother standing on the grass and included a ladder near him, with one hand reaching toward it. This depiction may suggest a wish to present himself as taller in the drawing, as height in children's imagery is often associated with feelings of strength, growth, or a desire for greater personal power (Fig. 31).

In Participant 8-2's drawing, the child depicted his father in two separate locations: inside the park's guardroom and outside it. Inside the guardroom, the father's figure appears heavily distorted and covered with dark, overlapping lines. A second depiction of the father is shown outside, positioned on the left side of the drawing. The child also portrayed himself as the first figure on the right side of the house, drawing his own body in a deformed manner and omitting one arm. Although several figures display smiling faces, the park contains no playful or lively elements typically associated with a cheerful environment. Instead, the dense and chaotic coloring, the absence of recreational features, and the fragmented visual composition may suggest an atmosphere that contrasts with a genuinely happy setting (Fig. 32).

Children produced drawings characterized by pale, scattered, and shaky lines (e.g., Fig. 21). This pattern was identified in 9 of the 28 children (31%). Frequent erasures were also observed in 4 children (14%), with examples shown in Figs. 24 and 25. In contrast, 21 children (75%) produced drawings marked by strong pen pressure on the paper, as illustrated in Fig. 22. Among children whose drawings were characterized by shaky, broken lines and light pressure, some also omitted the outlines of the figures' bodies (e.g., Fig. 23). This pattern was identified in 8 children (29%) and gave some figures a fragile or unstable appearance. In some cases, particular figures appeared visually weakened in comparison with others.

Other notable graphic features included linear and inflexible fingers, observed in 7 children (25%; see Figs. 24 and 25), and fan-shaped fingers, observed in 6 children (21%; see Fig. 26). More distorted or symbolic forms were also observed in some drawings, including monster-shaped figures (e.g., Figs. 17 and 22) and one-dimensional, frog-like forms (e.g., Fig. 20). Color use was another important feature, particularly when children depicted themselves in relation to family members. In this study, nearly 21% of participants drew themselves using colors different from those used for other family members. The most frequently used colors were red (14 children, 50%), green (9 children, 33%), and brown (4 children, 16%).

Additional recurring features included shading on specific parts of the body (17 children, 61%), aggressive defacement of figures (16 children, 57%), and a lack of integration among drawing components (14 children, 50%). Taken together, these findings indicate variation in line quality, bodily representation, symbolic distortion, and graphic organization across the children's drawings.

4. Discussion

This study examined how emotional and behavioral indicators associated with trauma and sexual abuse may emerge in children's drawings. The analysis revealed several recurring visual tendencies—including the omission or distortion of body parts, asymmetrical limbs, floating figures, and the use of darker or more angular



Fig. 17. Drawing created by Participant Code 17.



Fig. 20. Drawing created by Participant Code 27.



Fig. 18. Drawing created by Participant Code 23-1.



Fig. 21. Drawing created by Participant Code 3.



Fig. 19. Drawing created by Participant Code 23-2.



Fig. 22. Drawing created by Participant Code 7.

forms. Although these features are not diagnostic on their own, when interpreted alongside information about the child's lived experiences, they can serve as useful non-verbal cues for understanding emotional distress.

Three main elements appeared most frequently in the drawings: (1) the removal or distortion of the body, (2) the depiction of arms, hands, and fingers, and (3) the representation of the eyes. In the drawings, the mother was omitted by 8 children (29%). Additionally, 12 children (43%) did not depict themselves, and 6 children (21%) omitted the



Fig. 23. Drawing created by Participant Code 1.



Fig. 26. Drawing created by Participant Code 21.



Fig. 24. Drawing created by Participant Code 3.



Fig. 27. Drawing created by Participant Code 7.



Fig. 25. Drawing created by Participant Code 20.



Fig. 28. Drawing created by Participant Code 10-2.

father. Among the 8 children who had experienced abuse by their father, 3 (37.5%) omitted the father, whereas 5 (62.5%) omitted themselves. Two children depicted only themselves and their abusive father.

Notably, 66% of the children who had experienced abuse by their fathers also omitted the mother from their drawings. Within the broader literature on children's drawings, some studies suggest that children may exclude figures that evoke fear, conflict, or distress as a way of

regulating overwhelming emotions (Goldner & Frid, 2022). This perspective corresponds with the idea that omissions may function as attempts—often outside of conscious awareness—to distance oneself from emotionally charged relational experiences (Wimmer, 2019). In this context, the absence of the mother, or her depiction in a passive or silenced form (e.g., without a mouth), has been interpreted in previous work as a visual reflection of perceived non-protection or lack of intervention. However, these interpretations are grounded in existing theoretical frameworks, and the present study cannot confirm them directly. Additionally, cultural expectations, migration-related stress, or family dynamics specific to this population may also influence these omissions.

In several drawings, children also omitted their own mouths. Prior research has associated this feature with difficulties in expressing



Fig. 29. Drawing created by Participant Code 6-1.

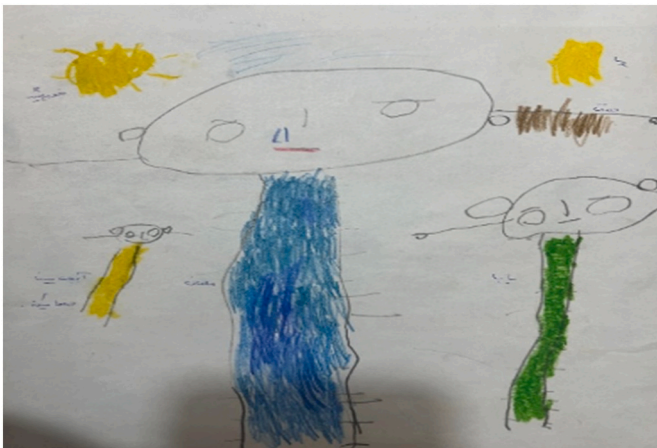


Fig. 30. Drawing created by Participant Code 10-1.



Fig. 31. Drawing created by Participant Code 12-1.

distress or seeking help among children who have experienced interpersonal trauma (Ballús et al., 2023). Interpretations in the literature vary, but such omissions have been linked to emotions such as fear, inhibition, or constraints around emotional expression within the child's environment.

In addition to omitting their parents, nearly 43% of the children also omitted themselves from their drawings. In the literature on children's self-figure drawings, self-omission has been associated with emotional withdrawal, reduced personal agency, and difficulties integrating



Fig. 32. Drawing created by Participant Code 8-2.

distressing experiences (Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022), although its meaning depends heavily on context. In this study, such omissions may be understood as reflecting a sense of psychological distance or diminished visibility of the self.

Furthermore, 18% of the children represented themselves either at a noticeable distance from family members or as younger than their actual age. Prior research indicates that spatial distancing in family drawings can be linked to feelings of emotional separation, loneliness, or reduced perceived support. Depicting oneself as younger has also been noted in some studies of trauma-exposed children and has been interpreted as referencing a period perceived as safer or less conflicted (Pace et al., 2022). These interpretations are consistent with findings that children experiencing relational distress often use spatial or developmental cues in their drawings to communicate their subjective experience of family dynamics. Some children in this study also produced drawings with deformed or altered body parts. Recent research suggests that body distortions can appear more frequently among children exposed to physical or multi-type maltreatment and may reflect discomfort with bodily experiences, heightened emotional distress, or difficulty organizing traumatic memories (Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022; Kissos et al., 2020; McInnes, 2019). These patterns have been linked to feelings of diminished self-worth, shame, and confusion—particularly when the body is central to the child's experience of harm. In this sense, body deformation may represent a symbolic expression of emotional strain or disrupted self-perception within the family context. Previous work has shown that children may express complex internal states such as inadequacy, fear, and sadness through distortions of the human figure (Farokhi & Hashemi, 2011), illustrating how drawings can function as vehicles for emotional communication rather than purely representational images.

Many children in this study omitted arms when drawing themselves or their family members, or depicted them as asymmetrical, shortened, horizontally positioned, or otherwise distorted. Earlier clinical literature linked such features to anxiety about actions involving the hands or arms, feelings of guilt or concern following inappropriate touching, and experiences of helplessness or reduced control (McInnes, 2019; Pont Amenós, 2012; Rose, 2017). More recent empirical studies reinforce a broader association between limb omission or distortion and emotional distress: research by Ballús et al. (2023) shows that the omission or deformation of body parts is more frequently observed among children living in emotionally tense, unsafe, or abusive environments. Similarly, a cross-cultural extension of this research further demonstrated that features such as omitted or asymmetrical limbs are widely treated as relevant indicators within coding systems used to identify potential maltreatment (Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022), even though not all indicators consistently differentiate maltreated from non-maltreated groups. In summary, the omission or distortion of arms in this sample

aligns with broader research suggesting that such features may reflect psychological strain or experiences of maltreatment; however, their interpretation must be situated within each child's developmental and relational context. It is also important to consider that cultural drawing styles or migration-related experiences may shape how children visually represent bodily control or emotional strain.

In this study, some children omitted legs or depicted them as unstable, shortened, or asymmetrical. Contemporary research on drawing-based assessments indicates that distortions or omissions of lower limbs function as visual indicators of emotional distress or possible exposure to maltreatment, rather than as fixed symbolic signs (Ballús et al., 2023; Dağlıoğlu et al., 2010; Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022, 2024). For example, Ballús et al. (2023) found that instability or absence of limbs forms part of broader figure-level disruptions in children living in unsafe or emotionally tense environments. Taken together, the distortions or omissions of legs observed in the present sample are best understood as potential indicators of insecurity, emotional disequilibrium, or difficulty integrating bodily experiences. Consistent with current best practices, these features should be interpreted cautiously and only alongside contextual, behavioral, and clinical information about the child.

In this study, some children depicted eyes in unusual ways, drawing them as dots, hollow, heavily shaded, or omitting them altogether. These features align with findings from self-figure drawing research, which suggests that some eye-related indicators occur more frequently in children with documented histories of child sexual abuse than in comparison groups (Jacobs-Kayam et al., 2013; Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022, 2024; Lev-Wiesel et al., 2020). Within this literature, minimal or absent eye detail has been described as reflecting difficulties in “seeing and being seen,” emotional withdrawal, or discomfort with interpersonal visibility (Lisi et al., 2013). However, recent systematic reviews emphasize that these indicators lack diagnostic specificity and may also appear in the drawings of non-abused children (Allen & Tussey, 2012; Lisi et al., 2013). Consequently, contemporary authors recommend treating such features as low-threshold screening cues rather than as diagnostic signs. In line with this perspective, we interpret unusual or minimal eye detail in our cases as a possible marker of emotional distress, dissociation, or relational withdrawal. These features may guide clinicians in exploring the child's interpersonal experiences and sense of safety, but they should not be treated as stand-alone evidence of child sexual abuse.

Recent research indicates that facial configurations—such as wide or pronounced smiling mouths—may be associated with particular emotional patterns or maltreatment-related indicators (Ballús et al., 2023; Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022; Lev-Wiesel et al., 2024). However, recent reviews of projective techniques emphasize that such indicators are most effective when used within structured scoring systems and in combination with other assessment tools, rather than as independent diagnostic signs (Santillo et al., 2025). In the present sample, only two participants (Codes 21 and 22) drew paternal figures with wide or accentuated lips, despite multiple reports of physical or emotional violence within the group. Consistent with contemporary findings, this emphasis on the mouth is considered hypothetically and only in conjunction with other graphic indicators and contextual information about the child's experiences, and is not interpreted as a definitive or determinative sign on its own.

Recent research indicates that children's depictions of hair may serve as a non-specific indicator of emotional distress, particularly in the context of trauma. Heavily shaded, darkened, or exaggerated hair has been associated with anxiety and heightened arousal, whereas upward, needle-like strands may reflect hostility or internal conflict; in contrast, soft and fine lines may signal a need for protection or reassurance (Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022). Evidence from self-figure drawing studies further suggests that children with histories of sexual abuse sometimes emphasize hair more prominently than children exposed to emotional abuse and, in some instances, more than those exposed to physical abuse (Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022). In our sample, several children

accentuated hair through intense shading, strong pressure, or upward strokes. Although hair emphasis is not a diagnostic marker of sexual abuse, when interpreted alongside other visual cues and contextual information, it may reflect elevated emotional strain among children who have experienced various forms of maltreatment.

Recent studies suggest that the use of angular or sharply contoured lines in children's drawings may reflect heightened emotional tension or dysregulation rather than indicating a specific stress-inducing figure (Ballús et al., 2023). In our sample, some children used angular lines when depicting both themselves and family members, which may point to broader emotional strain within the family context.

Shading of specific body areas also appeared in several drawings. Intense or repeated shading, particularly with strong pressure, has been linked to bodily discomfort or heightened emotional focus (Ballús et al., 2023). In our study, shading was more frequent on the father's hands and genital region. Although shaded genital areas have been reported in some drawings of sexually abused children (Jacobs-Kayam et al., 2013), current reviews indicate that only the explicit depiction of genitalia shows relatively consistent association with sexual abuse; shading alone has low specificity and requires cautious interpretation (Jaroenkajornkij et al., 2022; Lev-Wiesel et al., 2024).

Some children also scribbled over or defaced faces, including their own. Trauma-focused drawing research suggests that such defacement may reflect emotional conflict or discomfort toward the depicted figure, though findings are variable. Weak, broken, or shaky lines observed in a subset of drawings may similarly indicate anxiety or uncertainty (Lev-Wiesel et al., 2020) and are interpreted here as tentative indicators rather than diagnostic signs. Environmental elements in children's drawings—such as houses, trees, clouds, rain, and the presence or absence of doors and windows—are understood in contemporary research as broad emotional indicators rather than markers of any specific form of maltreatment. Recent empirical work using the House–Tree–Person Drawing Technique and related assessment methods suggests that constricted or structurally limited houses, including those with few details, closed façades, or no visible windows, may reflect feelings of insecurity, vulnerability, or reduced emotional openness among children experiencing stress or adverse circumstances (Guo et al., 2023; Manomenidis et al., 2025; Roysircar et al., 2017). However, these patterns do not exhibit diagnostic specificity for sexual abuse. In the present study, several children drew houses that appeared closed, uninviting, or lacking doors and windows. Consistent with recent findings, such depictions may signal perceptions of emotional withdrawal, limited communication, or environmental instability within the family system (Manomenidis et al., 2025; Woollett et al., 2023). Drawings of floating houses or floating family figures—observed in a considerable number of cases—have similarly been associated in recent literature with feelings of instability or a lack of groundedness, particularly among children affected by migration or displacement (Roysircar et al., 2017). Given that a substantial proportion of participants in this study were Afghan immigrants, such floating imagery may plausibly reflect experiences of social rootlessness alongside emotional distress.

Dark clouds, heavy rain, or storm-like elements also appeared in some drawings. Current evidence indicates that these motifs generally function as expressions of stress, anxiety, or negative affect and are frequently observed in the drawings of children without documented maltreatment histories (Manomenidis et al., 2025; Wimmer, 2019). Moreover, quantitative studies show that environmental indicators within the House–Tree–Person Drawing Technique, on their own, are not capable of reliably distinguishing sexually abused children from non-abused peers (Lin et al., 2022). Taken together, environmental elements in the present sample are interpreted as low-specificity emotional cues that may provide insight into the child's subjective experience when considered alongside figure-related features and contextual information, rather than as indicators of any particular type of abuse.

Other visually prominent features—such as the excessive use of

wedges and circles, the depiction of elongated tools or phallic-like objects, and darkened lines or markings near the clothing around the genital area—have been noted in earlier literature on drawings of children suspected of experiencing sexual abuse (Allen & Tussey, 2012; Sidun & Rosenthal, 1987). However, contemporary empirical research consistently demonstrates that only the explicit depiction of genitalia carries meaningful clinical relevance in cases of suspected sexual abuse. In contrast, indirect or ambiguous shapes—such as elongated objects, cylindrical forms, pointed tools, or phallic-like configurations—are considered even less specific and commonly occur in the drawings of children regardless of maltreatment history (Ballús et al., 2023). These motifs are generally attributed to developmental drawing tendencies, perceptual immaturity, exploratory mark-making, or generalized emotional tension rather than to symbolic sexual meaning.

In the present sample, a few children included elongated objects or darkened areas near the lower body region. Consistent with current evidence, such elements are interpreted cautiously and regarded as non-diagnostic, contributing meaningfully only when considered alongside other visual indicators, contextual information, and behavioral observations.

Some children in this study also incorporated positive or decorative motifs—such as flowers, hearts, butterflies, or rainbow-like imagery—into their drawings. Although such elements are common in children's artwork more broadly, a small number of studies involving maltreated populations suggest that these motifs may, in some cases, represent attempts to restore a sense of safety or to introduce soothing, emotionally regulating elements into drawings that otherwise convey distress. For example, Lev-Wiesel et al. (2018) found that some sexually abused children used flowers, butterflies, or heart symbols as metaphorical expressions of longing for protection or for a more secure relational environment, though these patterns were not consistent across participants. Similarly, a recent narrative review reported that decorative or aesthetic additions may help children “beautify” or regain a sense of control in their drawings when confronted with stress or adversity (Manomenidis et al., 2025). While these motifs are not indicators of abuse, they provide valuable context for understanding why positive symbols may co-occur with emotionally challenging or conflicted imagery in some children's drawings.

Some children in the present study included rainbow-like imagery in their drawings. In the broader literature, rainbows are often described as positive or hopeful motifs and may, in some cases, reflect a child's wish for safety or emotional relief when facing difficult experiences (Goldner et al., 2021). In one study on abuse-related drawings, for example, a child explicitly used a rainbow to represent “the opposite of violence” and titled the image *Rainbow of Peace* (Goldner et al., 2021). It is also plausible that some children add soothing or stabilizing elements—such as rainbow imagery—after depicting distressing material, as a way of reintroducing emotional balance or a sense of safety into their drawings. Although rainbow motifs are not indicators of abuse, they may offer contextual insight into how children attempt to regulate or counter-balance emotionally challenging content within their visual narratives.

Some children in the present study included ladder motifs in their drawings, in some cases with an arm extended toward the ladder. Drawing a ladder with an outstretched arm has been described in interpretive literature as a possible expression of a child's wish for freedom, escape, or the sense that desired conditions feel out of reach—particularly when the arm is drawn with faint or fragile lines (Atherton & Nutbrown, 2016; Athey, 2007). However, there is little empirical research linking ladder drawings to specific forms of maltreatment. Contemporary work on children's graphic schemas suggests that ladders and other vertical structures more commonly reflect children's exploration of vertical movement or “up-down” trajectories, and may also appear as transitional forms in drawing development rather than functioning as fixed symbols of particular emotional states (Deguara & Nutbrown, 2018).

Within the art-therapy literature, ladders have been discussed more

broadly as potential metaphors for effort, movement, or change in narrative and play-based work. Authors emphasize, however, that such interpretations are highly context dependent and should only be inferred—if at all—from the full composition of the drawing, the accompanying narrative, and knowledge of the child's lived circumstances, rather than from the presence of a ladder alone (Atherton & Nutbrown, 2016; Athey, 2007). Accordingly, in the present study, ladder motifs are understood as possible components of children's broader emotional or metaphorical narratives. Any meaning they may hold is interpreted only in combination with other graphical features and contextual information, and they are not regarded as indicators of sexual abuse.

Children in this study sometimes included stormy weather, rain, or dark clouds in their drawings. Research on weather-related motifs indicates that such imagery generally reflects stress, worry, or difficult circumstances rather than any specific form of maltreatment (Jones & McNulty, 2022). Studies conducted during illness, lockdown, or disaster contexts likewise show that dark or stormy skies frequently appear in children's drawings when they feel anxious or threatened (Haring, 2023). Although older art-therapy sources linked combinations of weather elements to sexual abuse (Cohen-Liebman, 1995), more recent reviews emphasize that environmental motifs have very low specificity and cannot distinguish abused from non-abused children (Allen & Tussey, 2012). Accordingly, in the present study, stormy weather and similar elements are interpreted as broad emotional cues that gain meaning only when considered alongside the full drawing and the child's life context.

5. Practical implications

Drawing analysis can help professionals identify children who may require further assessment, guide therapeutic conversations, and support trauma-informed interventions by revealing themes such as helplessness, disrupted attachment, or internalized shame. By integrating drawing-based observations with clinical interviews, behavioral assessments, and contextual information, professionals can develop a more holistic understanding of the child's psychological state and recovery needs. These indicators should not be used for diagnostic purposes and gain clinical relevance only when interpreted together with interviews, behavioral observations, and contextual information about the child's environment and developmental history.

6. Limitations and future directions

The absence of a non-abused comparison group limits the ability to determine whether specific drawing features are unique to sexual abuse or reflect broader experiences of stress, adversity, or emotional dysregulation. In addition, the cultural and migration context of this sample—consisting largely of Afghan immigrant children living in Iran—may have influenced the expressive tendencies observed. Therefore, the visual indicators described in this study should not be generalized without caution. Although aspects of the use of graphic space—including partial use of the page, overcrowding, or even a near-compulsive filling of the paper—have been discussed in the literature as potentially meaningful in the drawings of abused children (e.g., Lisi et al., 2013), these features were not systematically examined as separate variables in the current study. Future research should investigate such spatial characteristics more rigorously and interpret them in light of children's lived experiences and contextual backgrounds. Future studies should include control groups, employ mixed-method clinical assessments, and examine children from diverse cultural and migration contexts to clarify which drawing elements are trauma-related in general and which, if any, may be more closely associated with particular forms of maltreatment. Such work would help refine the clinical use of drawing analysis and strengthen its role within trauma-informed care.

7. Conclusion

In light of these limitations, this study identified recurrent visual patterns in the drawings of children with documented histories of sexual abuse using a child-level unit of analysis and a triangulated interpretive approach that considered the drawings, the children's verbal explanations, and contextual information from caregivers. Floating figures and objects emerged as the most frequent visual feature, alongside recurring indicators such as omissions and distortions of body parts, limited or altered facial detail, and spatial distancing within family scenes. These features were observed in the drawings of children with documented histories of sexual abuse; however, they should not be understood as specific or diagnostic markers of sexual abuse. In particular, floating figures and objects may reflect emotional distress as well as migration-related instability or social rootlessness, especially given that a substantial proportion of the participants were Afghan immigrants. When interpreted together with clinical interviews, behavioral observations, and knowledge of the child's life circumstances, such graphic elements may serve as non-verbal cues of emotional strain. The co-occurrence of distressing imagery with soothing or decorative motifs suggests that children may also use drawings as a means of emotional regulation, attempting to restore balance or a sense of safety within otherwise troubling visual narratives. Taken together, the findings support the use of drawing analysis as a complementary tool within trauma-informed assessment and intervention, helping professionals to better understand how children may symbolically communicate their internal experiences without relying on drawings as standalone evidence of abuse.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Azam Pilevari: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Validation, Supervision, Project administration, Methodology, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Mobina Zandieh:** Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation. **Maede Baniamerian:** Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation. **Zahra Taghipour:** Writing – review & editing.

Declaration of Generative AI and AI-assisted technologies in the writing process

The authors confirm that no generative AI tools were used for data collection, coding, case interpretation, or any analytical process in this research. A language model (ChatGPT) was used only to assist in text revision and language refinement during manuscript preparation. All scientific content, interpretations, and conclusions were developed solely by the authors, who take full responsibility for the accuracy and integrity of the work.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors have declared no conflicts of interest.

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Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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